

What's Next: Some Early Take Aways from Carolina Across 100

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In 2021, the University launched an ambitious, five-year experiment: Carolina Across 100 (CX100), an effort to implement evidence-based programming statewide. Community partners across North Carolina delivered more than 130,000 services, and over 99 percent said their communities improved as a result. More than 30 campus units contributed. That success is worth celebrating, but CX100 also taught us what it takes to do community-engaged work together, as a campus, and some of those lessons are worth sharing widely and building upon.

Meaningful engagement is not simply about bringing the University's expertise into communities. It is about building relationships that can hold complexity, creating structures that measure impact and support ongoing collaboration after campus engagement ends, and recognizing that communities themselves are not just recipients of knowledge — they are essential partners in shaping it.

This memo lays out some early takeaways for the [Carolina Engagement Council](#) (CEC) – the guiding body of CX100. The lessons are practical and institutional. Most are drawn from the five cross-sector community collaboration programs (Our State, Our Work; Our State, Our Wellbeing; Our State, Our Homes; Our State, Our Future; and Care4Youth), although many are applicable to the two other programs (the Tar Heel Bus Tour Grants and RuralRx). Together, they can guide what comes next as UNC defines what it means to be “the first in public universities.”



CAROLINA ACROSS



Demonstrating Institutional Commitment

Trust Matters. Despite data indicating deteriorating trust in higher education institutions, communities clamored to partner with UNC when offered the opportunity. Community teams included people from different sectors, higher education “loyalties,” and ideologies. They sought to participate in the programs because they believed our campus would be a good partner. CX100 was building on a long-standing commitment to serving the state and the positive outcomes reinforced trust in UNC.

Complex challenges require complex engagement responses. Our inaugural program, Our State, Our Work, set out to reengage young adults disconnected to employment or education after absences attributable to remote learning and fewer jobs in services — and quickly revealed needs far more interconnected challenges than expected. We rallied campus experts across food security, mental health, child care, justice, disabilities, and workforce development, plus outside partners like the NC Community College System. The result: over 16,000 services delivered in ways no single discipline’s effort could have matched. We demonstrated that UNC is well positioned to tackle the state’s most complex challenges but only by resourcing genuinely interdisciplinary teams.

Commitment isn’t capacity. Community demand for partnerships sometimes overwhelmed our capacity. In one program, for example, we declined requests to participate from over 20 counties because we could not operate at the scale that would have required. This capacity issue challenged the campus across the program even though more than 1,200 UNC faculty, staff, and students stepped up to support the effort.

Recruiting campus engagement at scale requires clear pathways. We recruited campus contributors mostly through existing relationships and networks. The CEC helped secure participation from 30+ unique units, and student teams leaned on listservs and friends. Without these networks, we would have relied on less effective marketing, such as impersonal flyers, emails and social media. The lesson: people respond more positively when messages come from people they know. Without deliberate infrastructure to connect interested faculty, staff, and students, our engagement could not have scaled to reach 100 counties. The Carolina Center for Public Service’s new project database and the Division of Student Success’s integrated supports are promising steps toward creating more durable pathways for engagement.

Campus investment signals seriousness. Chancellor’s Office seed funding let CX100 leverage over a 1:1 cash match from external sources. That does not begin to count the in-kind support from partners on and beyond campus. This wasn’t just a fundraising win; it was a signal. External funders invest more readily when the University visibly invests too.

Community capacity and time limits must be considered and discussed with partners. We screened partners carefully, but capacity is hard to predict. This is especially true for regional organizations covering multiple counties where impact often varies across the territory. Additionally, community challenges are ongoing, but campus resources are not. Even with sustainability built into our [Sync model](#) and our continued technical assistance and fundraising support after programs ended, some teams lost momentum, and others were frustrated that the campus could not continue to engage at the same level as during active programs. The lesson: have the hard conversations about campus resource limits early and often and ensure partners can sustain the work.

Valuing Community Knowledge and Voice

Listening, again and again, pays high dividends. Our year-long Community Listening Survey (Almost 3000 responses covering every NC county and 60+ follow-up interviews) shaped CX100’s direction from the outset, but staying responsive meant continuing to listen throughout. When both Our State, Our Work and Our State, Our Wellbeing community teams surfaced an urgent need around youth-focused mental health,

for example, we launched CARE4Youth in direct response. Communities were effusive in their praise for our campus' ability to hear and act on emerging needs, not just planned ones.

Presence in community matters. Site visits and direct interaction gave insights no Zoom or in person campus Forum meeting ever could. For Our State, Our Homes, an externally funded regional liaison who visited teams regularly became what partners called a “force multiplier” — deepening relationships, signaling respect, and making the work feel even more reciprocal. If UNC wants to be a genuine statewide partner, we need to support engagement that shows up physically beyond Chapel Hill.

Evidence must speak to community wisdom and needs. Campus research and best practices were core to the work but landed best when communities could easily adapt them to local context. One team learned from the Suicide Prevention Institute that firearms were the leading means of suicide locally. The team then worked with barber shops, an informal hub of trust, to distribute gun locks and start conversations, earning national recognition. Across the program, the quantitative data provided from campus helped us to see what was happening, but it was the community stories, like our “Stories of Thriving” in Our State, Our Work, that helped us understand why things were unfolding as they were in communities. The community expertise gave our work depth. The opportunity ahead: invest in two-way translation, not just campus to community dissemination.

Measuring, Sustaining, and Communicating Impact

Rigorous assessment of programmatic impacts is hard. With no control communities and no long-term evaluation budget, attribution was always going to be difficult. Our Shared Measurement System helped align metrics across cross-sector teams, but local leaders juggling full-time jobs understandably sometimes could not prioritize data tracking over providing services.

Sustainability depends on how the work is rooted. Teams built upon existing coalitions and well-connected organizations were better positioned to carry the work forward beyond the period of formal support, while teams built from scratch to participate in programs struggled to maintain momentum without it. This observation underscores the reality that communities don't exist through the lens of campus engagement. They exist through institutions and relationships that predate and outlast any single engagement project. Collaborative work is more likely to endure when it is woven into those existing relationships, networks, and institutions.

Community partners can be powerful messengers. Local media coverage, often in outlets that only cover UNC for athletics, broadened awareness of the campus commitment to the state and elevated community teams alike. But that amplification wasn't automatic; partners needed data, communication platforms, and co-created messaging to tell the story well. We were surprised by the thirst for communications support.

Lasting Impact through Overcoming Challenges to Success

Reporting requirements must be balanced against community capacity. Meeting external CX100 funders' requirements is important, but data collection needs can quickly overburden community partners. Co-creating data processes that start from what partners already track is essential. In addition, campus and external funders must be willing to underwrite excess costs. As one cautionary tale, a funder who was excited about the work requested additional outcome data long after a grant ended. All that data had to be collected from community teams, but the funder did not offer additional resources. Given our campus commitment to avoid an extractive approach, CX100 had to find new resources to compensate partners for the extra work. Lesson: Ensure external funders share the same values as your campus engagement effort.

Burdens of compensating campus and community partners compromise the work. Compensating campus and community partners for their contributions is important. That is especially true to avoid exploiting

community knowledge. In practice, however, University payment processes can be slow and burdensome, creating friction that undermines the very partnerships they are meant to support. In one case, a family's travel reimbursement for playing a key role at a statewide convening took nearly 18 months. The experience left the family quite frustrated. In addition, vendor setup can also be a particular barrier for individuals and small organizations. The burden sometimes falls on faculty and staff, who spend considerable time navigating campus systems. Fortunately, the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Research is working on right-sized policies that support community engagement research by avoiding unnecessary burdens.

Consistent definitions and expectations promote engaged scholarship. CX100 demonstrated a strong appetite among faculty and staff for community-engaged work. However, colleagues hold varying understandings of what “community-engaged scholarship” means. Greater clarity, especially around how this work fits into appointment, promotion, and tenure, would help early-career faculty engage communities with greater confidence that the work does not risk their professional success. Again, the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Research is working to respond to this need.

We have a chance to make generative AI a game changer in campus engagement with communities.

Sometimes frustrated by access barriers to campus expertise, communities are increasingly turning to AI for timely answers, sometimes drawing — whether they realize it or not — on knowledge our campus helped create. In this way, AI complements, not competes with, our engagement work. UNC's opportunity going forward is to be more intentional in providing access and discernment for communities by leveraging what AI offers while providing what it can't replace. This approach will leave communities with greater capacities and confidence in AI and the campus. UNC's Library leadership was a critical partner in helping the core CX100 team develop ways to incorporate AI into its interactions with teams. The Library has extended its work to training local libraries on AI use.

What These Lessons Mean for Campus

Community engagement isn't an add-on or a temporary endeavor for UNC. It has been core to our mission since the founding of our campus, and the benefits are too significant, and too mutual, for us to step back now.

CX100 has shown what's possible when the campus listens carefully, shows up consistently, and invests meaningfully in communities. We will move forward in our respective community engagement efforts large and small, and we will all need the infrastructure, staffing, funding, and relationships to make those efforts easier, stronger, and more sustainable. We can build on CX100's learnings about:

- the importance of effective internal networks connecting faculty, staff, and students;
- more ways to value community stories and expertise alongside our data and evidence-based practices;
- greater investment in local partnerships with physical presence across the state; and
- increased financial commitments that match the seriousness of the work.

What do you suggest as next steps?